SmatterPlot v1.0

Help Files and Documentation

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Introduction

SmatterPlot is a small, easy-to-use, versatile app for creating instant charts. The user only needs to drag-and-drop or copy-and-paste their data into the SmatterPlot window and the chart appears instantly. The user can then customize the chart with only a few clicks and can then export the chart image in whatever format they need.

SmatterPlot is intended to make charting easy for anyone ... students and teachers, scientists and engineers, business professionals or small business owners. Obviously, people who already make charts often will already have other software tools for this, but SmatterPlot may offer a quicker way to get a good chart with minimal effort. Less experienced chart makers will probably the most benefit from the quick download and minimal learning curve.

Under Development

SmatterPlot is not quite ready for prime time -- I'm still working on it. But you might find it useful, and you are welcome to try it out now.

Features Planned

SmatterPlot will have a lot of features designed to make everything quick and easy. When it's finished it will be the quickest way to make a plot from data whether it is in spreadsheet or simply copied from the web.

Some planned Features include:

- Instant chart with drag-and-drop or copy-and-paste.
- AI-based chart design selection, so the user doesn't have to choose all the chart features -- they are just there immediately.
- Instant title, axis and series labelling based on context.
- Open data from a wide range of formats (.xlsx, .csv, .txt, etc.)
- Generate charts in a wide range of image formats (.png, .jpg, .svg, .pdf, etc.)
- Instant unit conversions right in the chart.

- Instant zoom, pan, and resize.
- Easy customization of colors, styles, sizes, symbols, lines, etc.
- Easy sequencing of series with color, symbol, and line grouping.

Available for Many Platforms

SmatterPlot is being developed in FreePascal which enables us to write code once and then compile versions of it for many different operating systems. When complete, SmatterPlot will be available for Windows, MacOS, Android, IOS, ChromeOS, Linux Ubuntu, and Raspberry Pi.

Questions or Comments?

Please contact us at david@smatterplot.com.

Getting Started

Download SmatterPlot

SmatterPlot is a small, easy-to-use, versatile app for creating instant charts. But first, you need to get the app installed on you device. It should be available in your app store, but you can always download it from the SmatterPlot website here (www.smatterplot.com) or from the SmatterPlot GitHub page here (https://github.com/offer8Simple/SmatterPlot).

Open the App

SmatterPlot when first open will look like this:

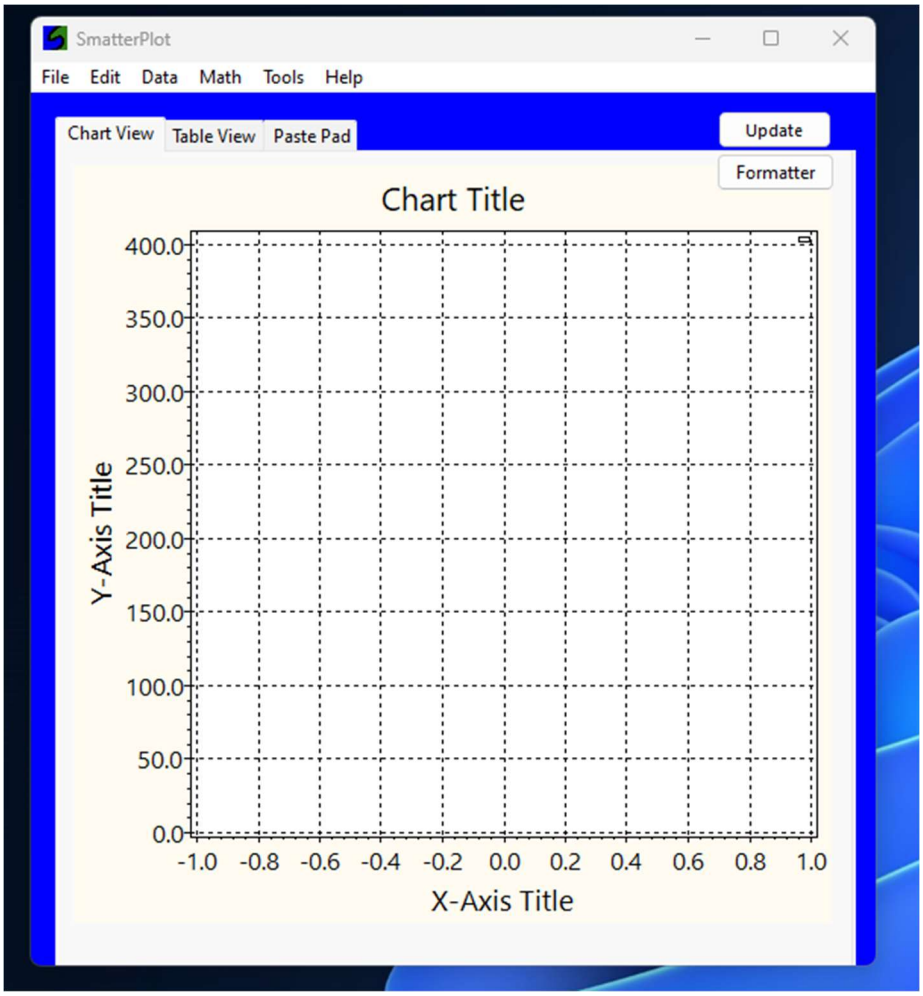


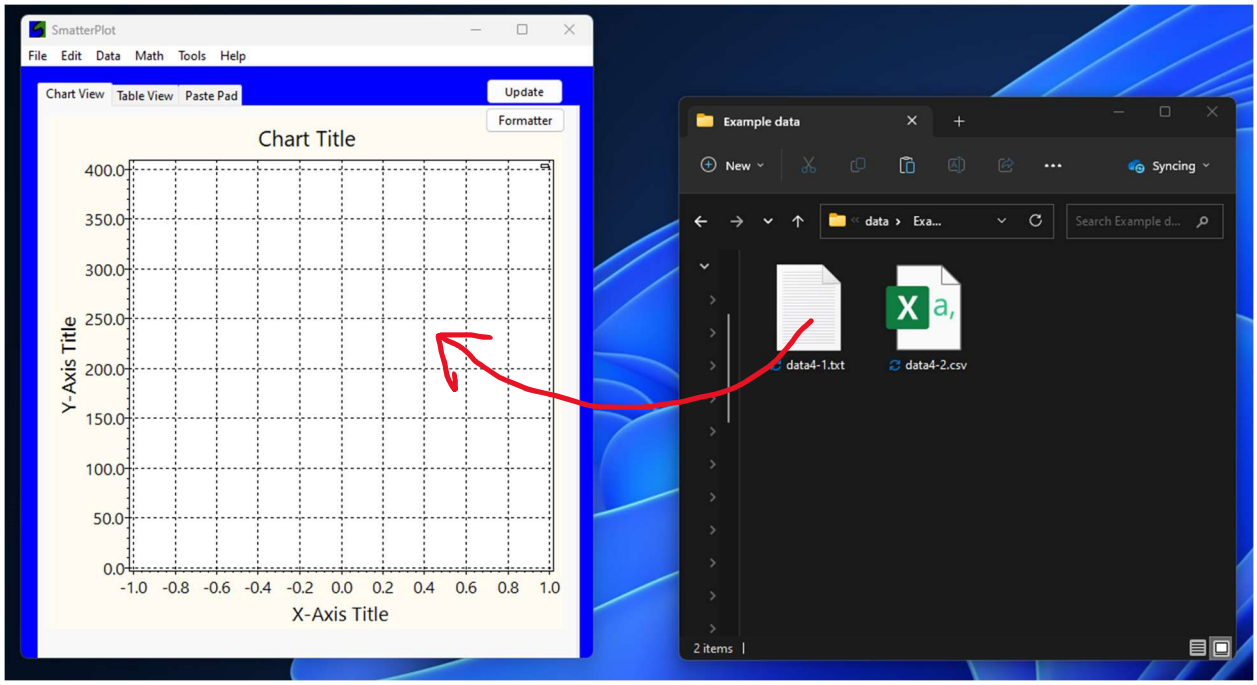
Figure 1: SmatterPlot when first opened.

Add Some Data

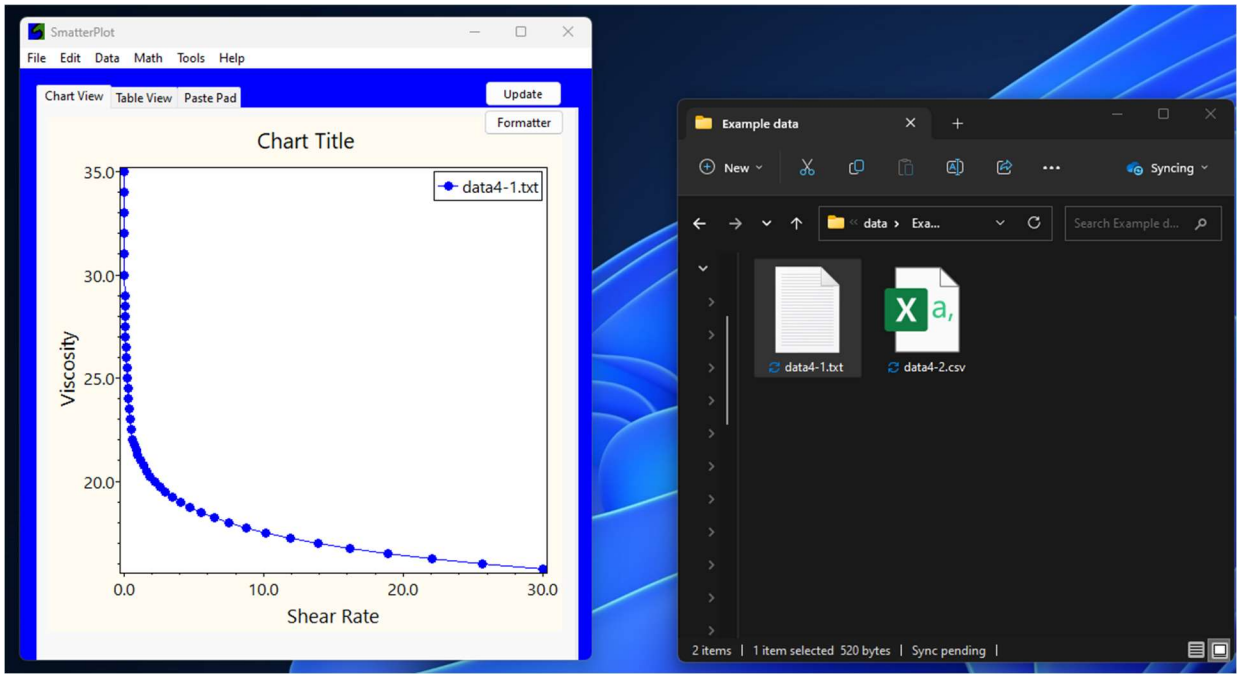
SmatterPlot isn't very useful until we add some data. There are four easy ways to do that:

1. Drag-and-Drop Data Files
2. Open Data Files Using the Menu
3. Copy-and-Paste Data in the Paste Pad
4. Type in your Own Data

To drag and drop a data file, just find the file you want on your device and drag-and-drop like this:

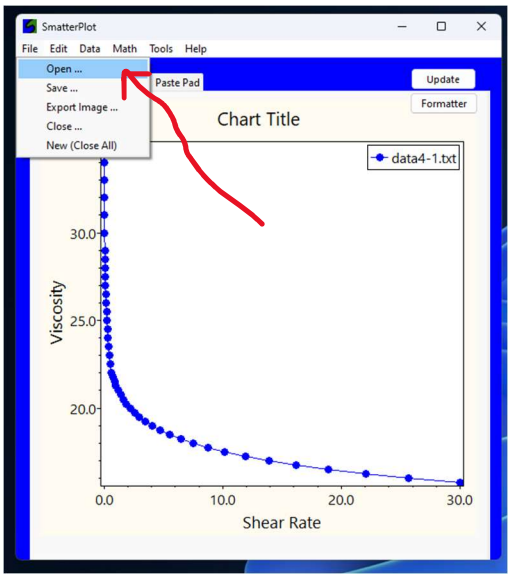


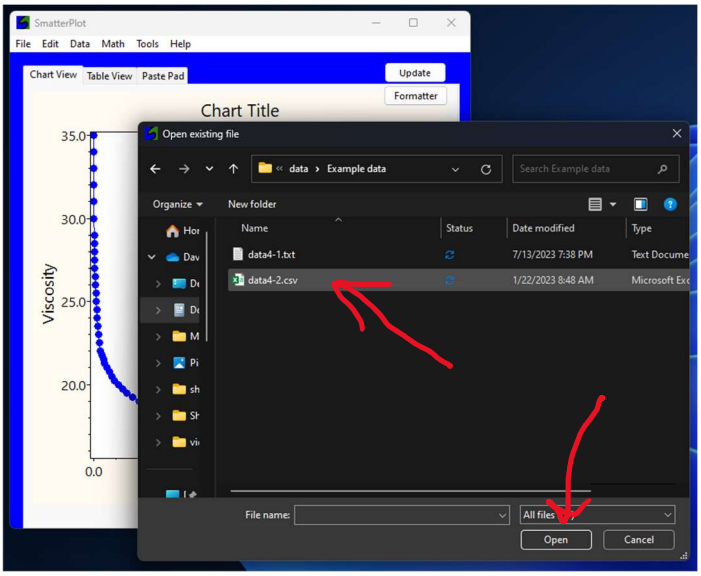
That's it! The datafile will open in SmatterPlot as a chart!

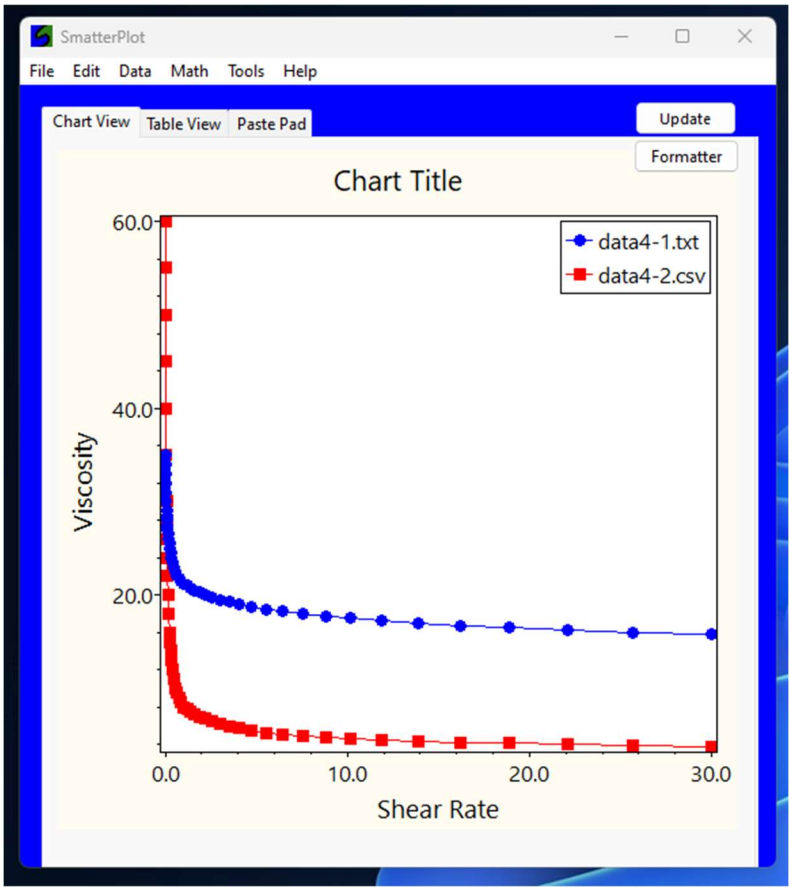


You can drag-and-drop multiple files at the same time. The files can be in wide range of formats such as .txt, .csv, or .xlsx.

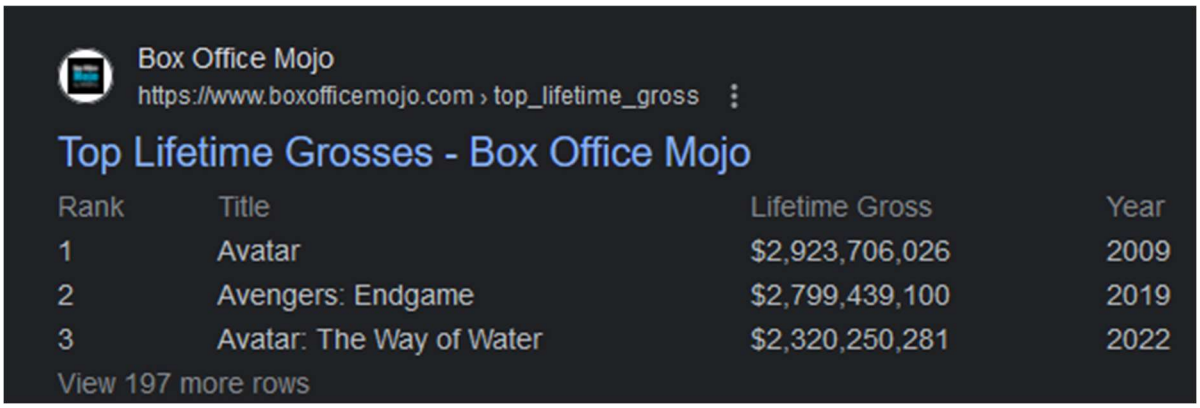
If you would rather pick the file to open from the file menu you can do that too. Click on “File” and “Open …” and then pick the file you want to open from the Open Dialog Box. The new file will overlay with whatever datasets are already open.



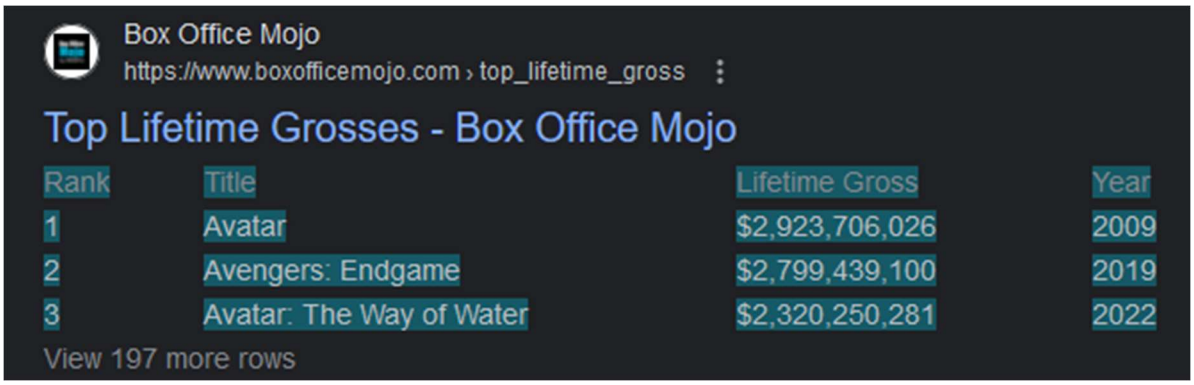




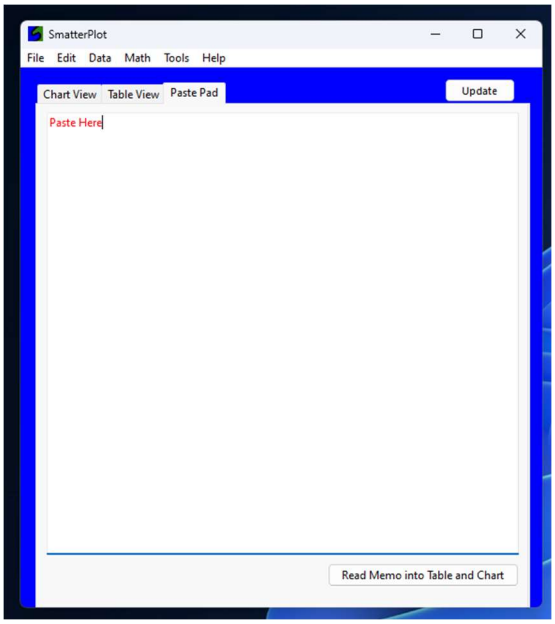
You can also copy and paste data from another application or maybe something interesting you found on the internet.

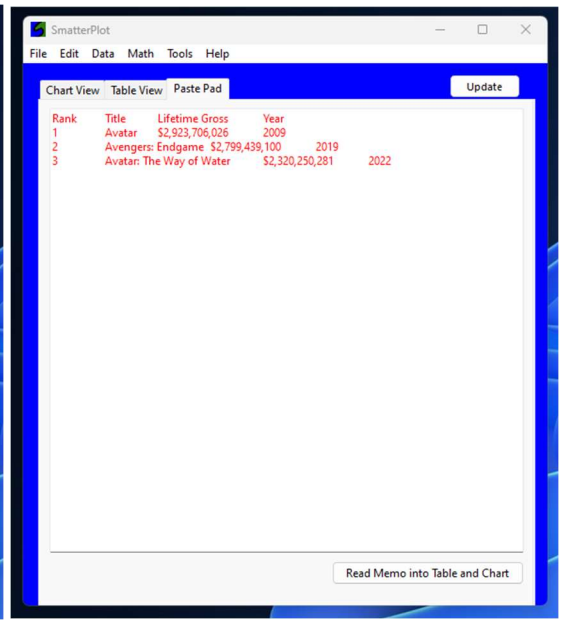


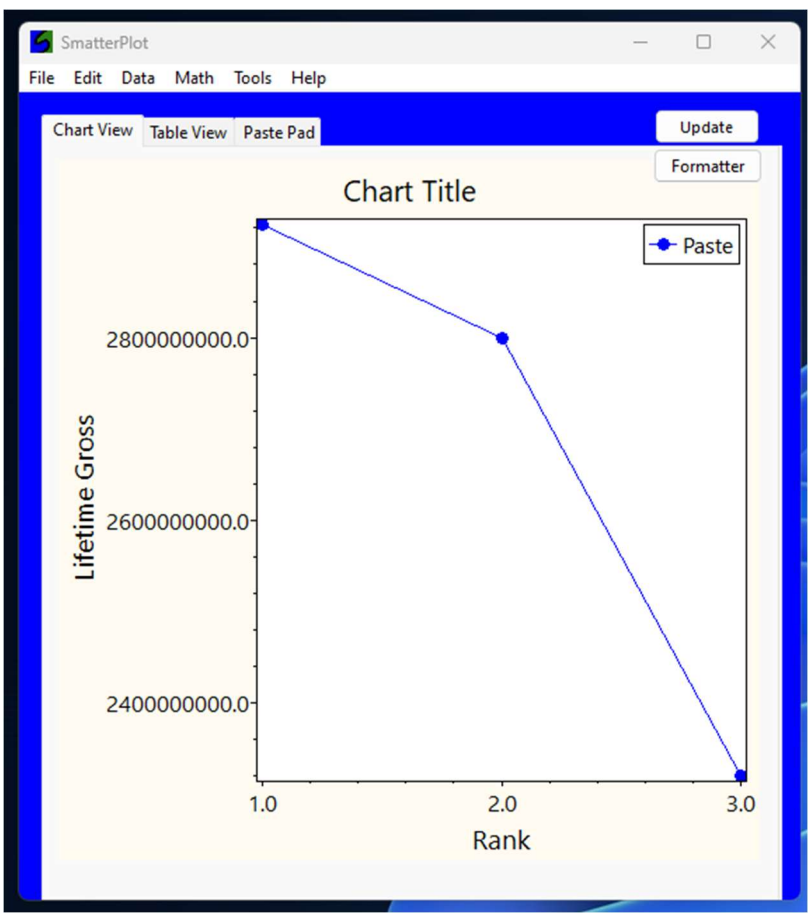
Just select the table and click “Copy” or in Windows you can use “Ctrl+C”:



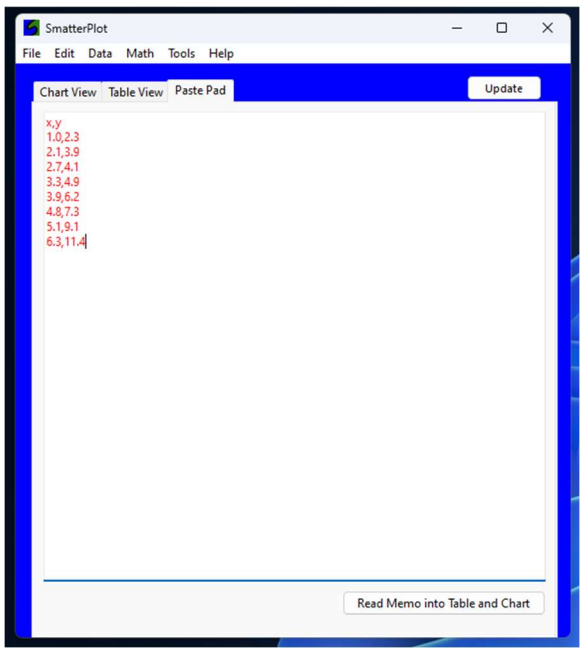
Then go back to SmatterPlot, click on the “Paste Pad” Tab and paste the table of data in the paste pad, either by clicking “Paste” under the edit menu or by hitting “Ctrl+V”. You can edit the table if you need to and then click “Read” to put the dataset in the chart. It’s that easy.

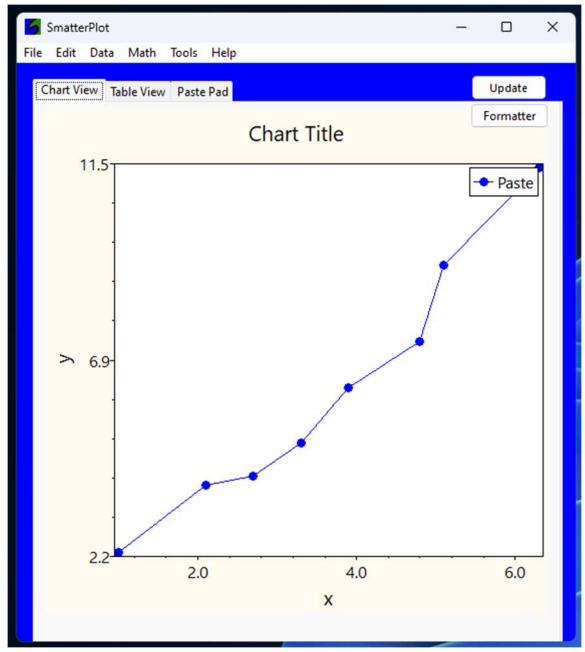






The last method is to type in the data using the paste pad. For example, you can type in this little table below. You can then click the “Read” button and it will plot your data!



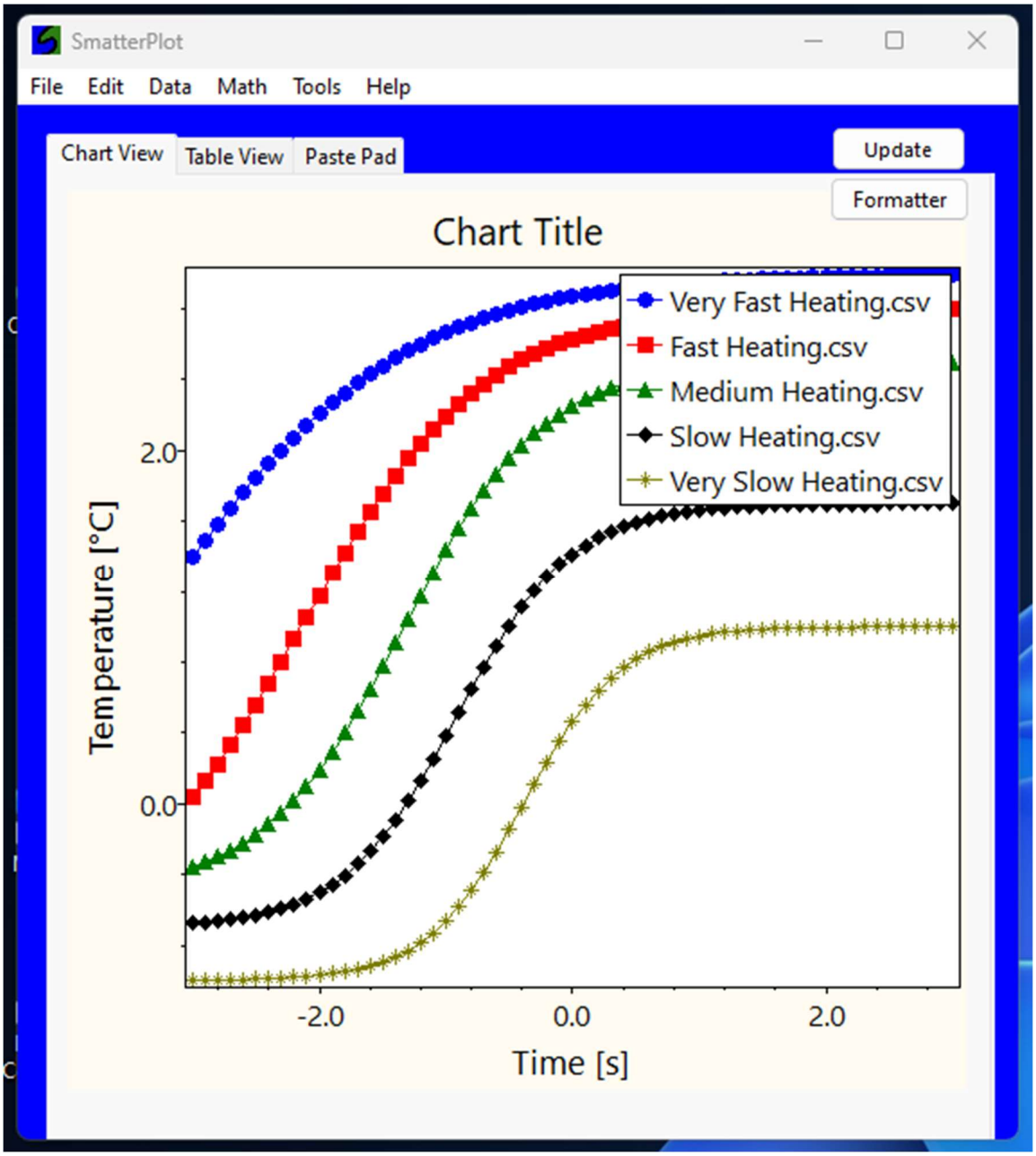


You can separate your columns with commas or tabs – either will work. You can add a header row, with column headings like “x” and “y”, but it’s not necessary.

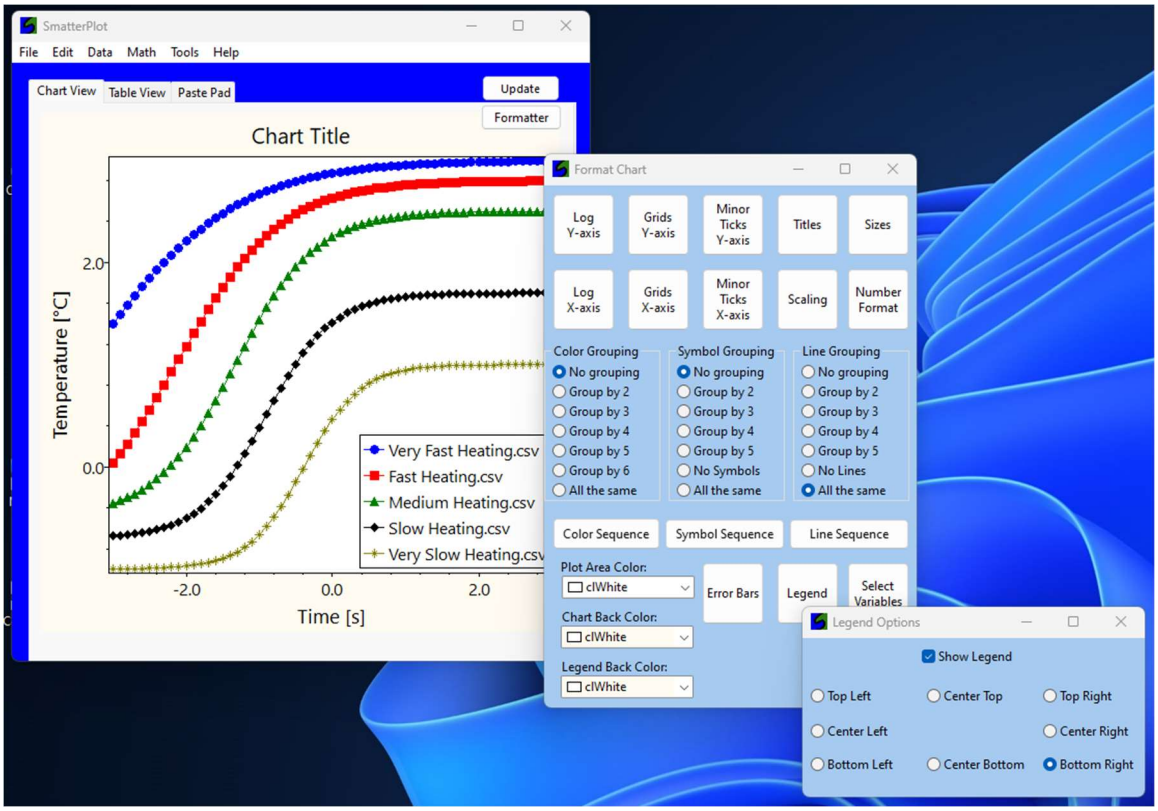
Formatting Your Chart

The Chart Formatter

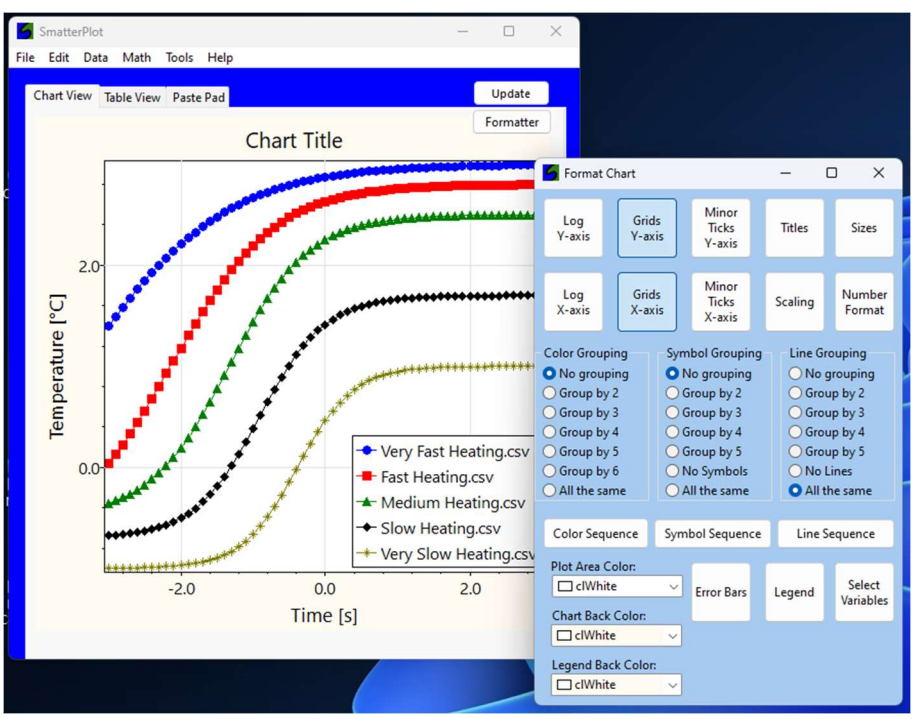
SmatterPlot automatically creates a chart to plot your data and automatically formats it so that you don’t have to make too many decisions unless you want to. But of course, you may want to customize the formatting so that it makes your point clearer. Let’s work through an example. In the examples folder there are five data files with different heating rates. Drag-and-Drop them into SmatterPlot to make a chart – This is what you get by default:



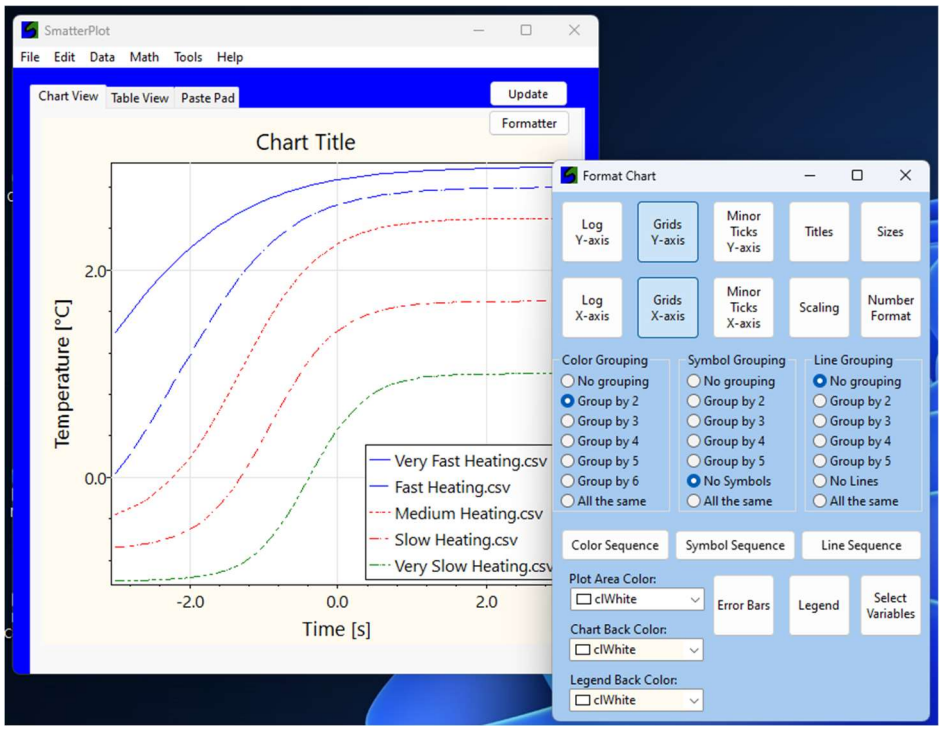
It actually looks pretty good already but you might want to change a few things. Open the chart formatter by clicking the “Formatter” button. Click the “Legend” button and then click the “Bottom Right” radio button to move the legend out of the way:



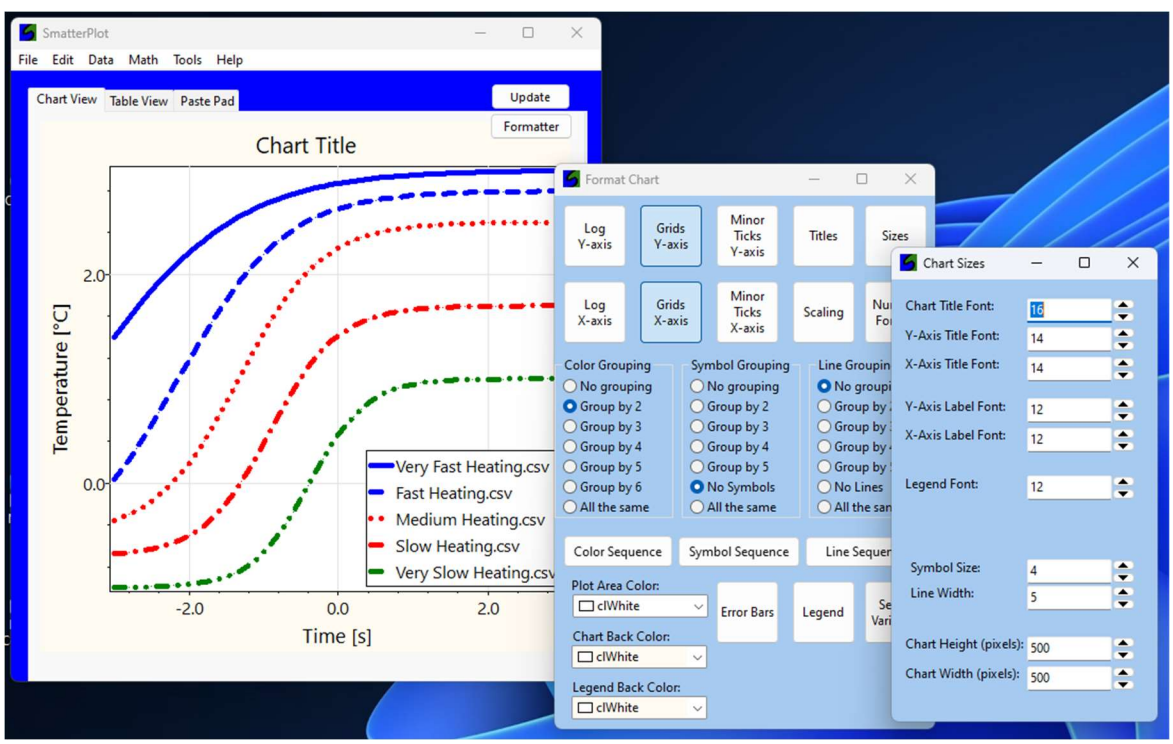
Then click the Grid lines button to toggle them on and off.



Now Customize the Color Sequence by clicking Group by 2 under color grouping. Click no symbols and then click No grouping under Line grouping.



Maybe the lines are too small to see clearly – lets increase their width by clickling “Sizes” and then clicking the up arrow next to the line width.



Now let's increase the size of the fonts and then change the chart title to something more meaningful by clicking "Titles". We can delete the ".csv" from the chart legend and then we get a chart that looks like this:

This is just a quick overview, but the point is that you can customize the chart in only seconds and produce a chart that is very presentable without painful effort.